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From Spectacle to Speech

*Voice, Authorship, and the Politics of Madness in Suetonius and Tezer
Özlü*

WRITTEN IN RESPONSE TO THE ASSIGNED PROMPT

*How do literary texts written by mad persons differ from those written about mad
persons? What differences in genre and literary form do persons claiming madness
utilize, and how does the employment of the literary allow them to redefine
“madness”?*

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In his *History of Madness*, Michel Foucault describes the “Great Confinement” of the seventeenth century as the mass institutionalization of those deemed socially unproductive, including the insane. This moment was significant to Foucault as it marked an epistemic rupture: madness ceased to be regarded as a bearer of its own truth, but instead as a moral failing, subject to condemnation and social exclusion. Indeed, during the Middle Ages and Renaissance, unreason was permitted a pivotal place within society. Satirical plays of the period featured figures such as the Fool, through whom the action could hold a mirror to itself (Foucault 13). Positioned outside the dominant narrative as they were, both literally and cognitively, they could see what reason overlooked, and their deviation was valued as a way of perceiving the world, rather than as a condition to be cured. However, these forms of exchange were dampened with the onset of the Great Confinement, which pathologized unreason and thereby recast the speaking fool into the mute patient.

Such is the conceptual foundation upon which our understanding of madness is built. The mad subject can be diagnosed and classified, but no longer heard, and is thus intelligible only in its opposition to rationality, rather than as an alternative language of experience. Though writing long before Foucault, Suetonius’s *Life of Caligula* provides an apt example. Because the emperor’s madness is narrated from an external vantage point, his seemingly irrational behaviours are moralized to restore coherence to a dominant historiography. By contrast, in Tezer Özlü’s *Cold Nights of Childhood*, madness speaks from within: a fragmented voice that refuses containment. Through its unconventional syntax and lyrical introspection, Özlü redefines madness as a perceptive consciousness—a way of being that reveals the unreason of the world around her, much like the stock Fool of the Renaissance.

Thus, the first and most obvious question is one of perspective, for the way madness is narrated delimits what can be known about it. In literature, voice is never neutral; it decides who possesses the right to interpret experience and who must exist within another’s account of it. Writing some eighty years after the emperor’s death, Suetonius is the arbiting voice in *Life of Caligula*, speaking from a position that presumes reason as the basis upon which all actions should be interpreted. When he recounts the emperor ordering a bridge of boats across the Bay of Baiae, the description is deceptively plain: “[Caligula] bridged the gap between Baiae and the mole at Puteoli, a distance of about thirty-six hundred paces, by bringing together merchant ships from all sides [...] Over this bridge he rode back and forth for two successive days.” (Suetonius 19). There is no

direct commentary on the act itself—yet the absence of explanation is itself a judgment. The image of the emperor riding triumphantly over the sea is left to stand as self-evident proof of some sort. By offering the event without motive, Suetonius invites the reader to fill in its meaning according to the logic of Roman decorum: what surpasses practicality must be excess, what exceeds measure must be lunacy. The historian's neutrality is thus a rhetorical strategy—an appeal to shared assumptions of reason that make further explanation unnecessary. A similar technique shapes his account of Caligula's conversations with the statue of Jupiter. "While in the daytime he would talk confidentially with Jupiter Capitolinus" (Suetonius 22). Again, the surface objectivity of the prose masks a moral framework beneath it. By withholding any speculation about intent—whether it was divine belief or theatre—Suetonius frames Caligula's behaviour as evidence of delusion to any outward observer. This calm, historical sobriety enacts exclusion: it denies the emperor an interior logic, a voice through which his actions might be understood as anything other than despotic.

As Mary Beard notes, Roman writers often had to reinvent themselves at regime change, producing histories that reaffirmed the moral order of the present (Beard 143). Writing as secretary to Emperor Hadrian, Suetonius's diagnosis of Caligula thus doubles as a political act: it reasserts the order of the new empire itself. But as Beard's discussion of Aloys Winterling suggests, Caligula's excesses might not have been symptoms of madness at all. Potentially, they could be read as a conscious unreason, wielded to detect the hypocrisies of imperial double-speak (Beard 140). Through this lens, madness would serve as critique, as it refuses to adhere to the linguistic games on which Roman power depended. However, Suetonius's moralizing framework, unable to conceive of unreason as anything but unwarranted, foreclosed that insight entirely.

Insight is precisely what Tezer Özlü's *Cold Nights of Childhood* offers. This auto-fictional account approaches perspective and voice in a manner diametrically opposed to *Life of Caligula*, embodying what Suetonius's historiography suppresses: the interior texture of madness itself. Written in the first person, Özlü constructs a consciousness that is intimate and unstable, where perception splinters yet persists in its pursuit of meaning. This reaches its most striking articulation when the narrator confesses, "Thoughts of death chase after me. Day and night, I think about killing myself. My reasons unclear. To carry on with life, or to die—either will do. A vague disquiet, nothing more. Troubled thoughts, pushing me towards giving suicide a try." (Özlü 25). Here, contemplation of suicide is rendered with striking plainness, without dramatization or acknowledgement

to its abnormality. Indeed, from the outside, such thoughts might seem excessive, yet within Özlü's narrative they belong naturally to the flow of consciousness. The colloquial phrasing "giving suicide a try" renders the act provisional and experimental: it both undercuts dramatic gravity and depicts the possibility of self-destruction as one more, albeit extreme, manoeuvre in the narrator's ongoing effort to make sense of herself. In this way, her unreason is never presented in contrast to what is typical, unlike Caligula, whose actions reach us solely through Suetonius's moral lens. Özlü's narrator speaks from within, making her experience legible on its own terms.

Then, as the scene unfolds, the voice grows more urgent. "I'm objecting to these houses, these armchairs and carpets, these teachers. This music. I'm screaming! You can have your little world. I'm screaming!" (Özlü 25). Here, the source of the narrator's turmoil finally comes into focus. What had earlier seemed vague now has an internal logic: her pain comes from the clash between her own desires and the suffocating conditions of her environment. Once again, the act of suicide itself isn't what draws attention. She is not preoccupied with dying, but with what her death might mean for the world she inhabits—"as if a beautiful dead body were a way of taking revenge." (Özlü 25). What matters, then, is not the so-called mad act itself, but what is expressed through it. This stands in sharp contrast to Suetonius's treatment of Caligula, where only his acts are recorded and the intent erased. By opening a complex inner space to the reader, Özlü utilizes unreason to interrogate the factors which produce it.

This etiological awareness is what gives *Cold Nights of Childhood* its critical force. Where texts written about mad people seek to define only its symptoms—curative in their rhetorical approach—Özlü reveals how such pathologized care can perpetuate the madness it claims to alleviate. The portion on electroshock is the most explicit confrontation of this: "Electroshock has a beginning and an end. But no midpoint. Not for the patient—the person. [...] I can still think and feel: 'So things have advanced to the point that they're giving me electroshock treatment/maybe they're giving me electroshock to make me talk again/...'" (Özlü 84). The insistence that the procedure lacks a "midpoint" captures the violence of an institution that allows no negotiation between unreason and reason. There is no space for dialogue—no meeting point between the world's expectations of reason and the subject's own understanding of herself. The treatment begins in one category (madness) and ends in another (sanity), eliding the complex interior terrain that lies between. This mirrors the logic of Foucault's *Great Confinement*, where the mad subject's voice is literally interrupted by the machinery of

cure. And Özlü answers this silencing through form in her fragmented prose. The insertion of a pause in “the patient—the person” becomes an act of resistance, the dash reinstating the human within the clinical, reasserting the personhood that medical discourse collapses.

Equally revealing is the narrator’s speculation that the shocks are “to make me talk again.” The phrase “talk again” carries a double resonance. On a deeper level than just literal, it evokes the institutional desire to make her speak within the accepted grammar of reason—to compel coherence rather than to listen. But the notation, divided by slashes, visually enacts the state of a consciousness fractured yet aware, trying to think through imposed muteness. And such is the literary technique that Özlü uses to convert spaces of pathology into acts of authorship. The passage dramatizes, at the level of syntax, the tension between being made to “talk again” and the deeper need to speak differently. Through this, *Cold Nights of Childhood* reclaims madness as a site of expression. What electroshock attempts to end becomes, in Özlü’s hands, the very material of her literature.

In the movement from Suetonius to Özlü, the representation of madness traces a shift from object to subject, from the spectacle of unreason to its speech. What *Life of Caligula* performs through biography, *Cold Nights of Childhood* dismantles through lyric fragmentation, allowing disorder to disclose its own logic. Suetonius’s form depends on distance; it organizes madness into history so that reason may define itself. Özlü’s depends on proximity; it dissolves narrative order so that madness may define itself anew. The distinction between texts written about the mad and those written by them, then, lies not simply in perspective but in the function of literature itself. Where the former uses narrative to restore coherence to a world unsettled by difference, the latter uses it to test coherence as a measure of truth. In Özlü’s hands, madness becomes a form of authorship—a way of thinking that exposes the fractures beneath the imposition of reason. Her prose reopens the dialogue that Foucault claimed was silenced by the Great Confinement, recasting unreason as a meaningful type of knowledge.